

Finishing What They Planted: A Collective Timeline for Mitsue's Forest (Early Draft)

Framing note (read first): This is not a Tokyo/gaikoku group arriving with a plan. It is a guide for how the existing Mitsue forestry structure — landholders, 森林組合, 丹羽製材, Mitsue Kanko, the village office — extends its own work one step at a time. Every stage below builds on structures that already exist (existing cooperative, existing processing center, existing landholder relationships). Nothing here proposes a new authority over the forest. The AI data center is fuel demand at the end of the chain — a customer for wood the collective already knows how to grow, not a reason to change who decides what happens on the mountain.

The goal is not money. Revenue is a side effect that keeps the work funded. The goal stated plainly: finish what the generation who seeded the sugi meant to finish — a forest that supports the people who tend it, not one that just stands there aging, as it has since the 1960s energy transition made it worthless to cut ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes]) Part A).

いのち — Inochi: the concept underneath every phase

Before the mechanics, the reason. The village's own 百年計画 (100-Year Plan) manuscript — written decades ago by a local author, not by us — opens not with agriculture policy but with a chapter titled simply いのち, "Life." Its argument, plainly stated:

- All life is one interconnected community — humans, forests, mountains, rivers share one root (一即一切, "the one is the all"). A forest is not a resource sitting apart from the people who tend it; it is the same life, expressed differently.
- The plan "begins with nurturing people and ends with nurturing people" (人づくりに始まり人づくりに終る) — infrastructure, income, and technology are downstream of that, never the starting point.
- Its own words on forestry, verbatim in spirit: *"We humans nurture forests, and forests are the wellspring of life — the source of the homeland of life. To protect this homeland of life, to cultivate it, to guard the forests — this is the fundamental purpose of forestry administration, and this is what a regenerative forestry administration must be."*
- And its opening call to action: *"One person alone can do nothing — yet nothing happens unless one person begins."* (一人では何もできない、一人がはじめなければ何もできない)

This is why the timeline below is paced in decades, not quarters, and why every phase asks "does this nurture people and forest together" before it asks "does this produce fuel." The CHP/AI-DC project doesn't introduce a new value system to Mitsue — it inherits one already written down by the generation that planted the sugi, and tries to actually finish it.

An outside echo of the same idea — Homo Sapiens to Homo Curans: the 100-Year Plan's いのち chapter was written independently of, and decades before, current academic sustainability theory — but it lands in the same place. In *Human Flourishing Across Cultures and Disciplines* (Zwitter, ed., Bloomsbury 2026), Ariel Hernandez proposes *Homo Curans* — "the caring human" — as a needed successor to *Homo Economicus*, the efficiency- and gain-optimizing model of human nature that has dominated policy and development thinking. Hernandez's argument, in short: humanness is more fundamentally *caring* than *calculating* — self-care, care for community, ecological care, and care extending to future generations are not soft add-ons to an economic actor, but the actual starting point for how a sustainable society should be built and governed. That reframing — from a species defined by what it can extract and optimize (sapiens as clever calculator) to one defined by what it tends and hands on (curans as caretaker) — is the same shift the 100-Year Plan is making when it puts 人づくり before infrastructure and calls the forest いのちのふるさと (the homeland of life) rather than a resource. Naming both together is useful

for outside audiences: this isn't a purely local or purely spiritual claim, it's a convergence between a Mitsue elder's handwritten manifesto and where international sustainability scholarship has independently arrived.

Why a timeline, and why this shape

Totman's Goryōrin history gives a real, documented case of Japanese sustained-yield forestry going from loss to a 40%-margin, multi-decade income base — proof this is not a novel or foreign idea, it's Meiji-era Japanese practice, done by people who lived with the forest. It also documents the two ways such plans die: a demand spike overriding the plan (1943–47, wartime "special harvesting"), and the plan outliving the reason anyone needed the wood (post-1950, fossil fuels and imports). The timeline below is built to avoid both failure modes — a supply ceiling that never lets short-term demand override long-term forest health, and a demand source (CHP + compute) engineered to last longer than one generation's energy transition.

The 100-Year Plan's own structure backs this pacing directly: it laid out its rebuilding in three deliberate phases — 20 years construction, 30 years construction, 50 years revision — a full century, because it treated forest and village regeneration as a single inochi-scale project, not a fundable-cycle one.

Timeline

Phase 0 — Listen and map what already exists (Months 0–6)

- Sit with landholders, 森林組合, 丹羽製材, and Mitsue Kanko to map who already controls what: felling rights, chipping capacity, storage, existing supply relationships.
- No new entity, no new land claim. This phase produces a map, not a proposal.
- **Why first:** Totman's Kan/Min chapter names the exact failure mode to avoid — reformers who were "urban samurai with little grasp of village life," who "learned as they legislated," and "confused, frustrated, frightened, and angered" the people they were supposedly helping ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes] Part B). Mapping before proposing is the direct antidote.
- **Guiding, not directing:** the collective decides what belongs on the map. An outside note-taker doesn't.
- **人づくり first:** the 100-Year Plan puts "nurturing people" before every other line item. Phase 0 is that in practice — the map is made of relationships and trust, not surveys.

Phase 1 — Small pilot on existing infrastructure (Year 1)

- Route a modest, known volume of already-planned thinning/off-take through the existing 牛峠 processing center — no new capex, no new building.
- Test the six-stage supply chain end to end at small scale: locate → fell → transport → store → distribute → pay ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes] Part C, the "hourglass" model) — and find where the real bottleneck sits, because it will not be where anyone assumed.
- One small CHP unit, sized to this pilot volume, not to a target.
- **Ownership stays local:** the pilot runs as an extension of existing 丹羽製材/cooperative operations, not a project office.
- **Forest as partner, not input:** the pilot is framed to participants as testing whether the forest can be cared for and used at once — the 100-Year Plan's "partner of life" (いのちの相手) framing for agriculture applies just as directly to forestry.

Phase 2 — Formalize terms the collective can live with for decades (Year 1–2)

- Draft a forward-supply arrangement modeled on nenkiyama — partial payment at agreement, balance after harvest — so growers recoup afforestation cost early and the buyer (CHP/DC demand) carries the growing-period risk, not the other way around ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes] Part C).
- Set a hard supply ceiling in writing before volume grows. This is the single most important clause in the whole plan: Totman documents in unambiguous detail what happens when a demand spike is allowed to override a sustained-yield plan — 1942→1944 harvest jumped 8.6M→10.97M koku, achieved by cutting reforestation spending, and the forest never fully recovered the plan's credibility afterward.
- If land tenure questions can't resolve cleanly to one owner, don't force it. Totman's koyuchi precedent — a legitimate, historically-used "shared use, defined rights" middle category — is a real option, not an evasion ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes] Part B).
- **Why now:** terms are easiest to set fairly before volume and value grow. Historically, supplier leverage grows over time as producers organize (Part C) — building that expectation into contracts now, rather than resisting it later, keeps the relationship durable.
- **The ceiling is an inochi commitment, not just a business term:** it exists so short-term demand never again overrides the forest's own pace — the same discipline the 1943 collapse shows was missing, and the same respect for life's own rhythm the 100-Year Plan asks for.

Phase 3 — Expand the existing cooperative structure, don't build a parallel one (Year 2–4)

- If new landholders or suppliers want in, use the guild-license precedent (kabu nakama → ikada han kabu): create a new, narrower membership class inside the existing cooperative structure, rather than a new organization competing with it ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes] Part C).
- Grow CHP/DC demand only as fast as the pilot's actual sustainable off-take supports — the Sanru rule of thumb (~33–50% of standing stumcock per cut, matched to growth rate) is a usable, defensible ratio to cite.
- Triage remaining forest parcels using the three-tier classification (unproductive / potential / productive timberland) so effort goes where it pays off, not everywhere at once.
- **Still guiding:** the AI DC operator proposes volumes it needs; the cooperative decides what it can sustainably supply. The ceiling is set by the forest's growth rate, not by compute demand.
- A workforce echo worth naming: the 100-Year Plan itself proposed a locally-staffed "Forest Environment Conservation Corps" (森林環境保全隊) to carry out exactly this kind of expanding forest work — the idea of growing local forestry capacity step by step, rather than importing it, is already the village's own idea.

Phase 4 — Reforestation catches up with harvest (Year 3–7)

- Every off-take cycle pairs with native broadleaf replanting in the areas the collective and more trees have already agreed on ([project_reforestation_principle]) — this is explicitly choosing the gen'ya (mixed, wildlife-forage woodland) side of the old sanrin/gen'ya tension, not the dense-conifer plantation side, and that choice should be named openly with forestry-trained partners who may default to conifer assumptions.
- This is the phase that actually answers the founding question: finishing what the generation who planted the sugi meant to finish — not a monoculture stand, but a forest a village can live from.
- Wildlife-forage regrowth also directly reduces the village's ~¥5.1M/yr deer/boar prevention cost ([reference_wildlife_prevention_budget]) — a real, local, non-monetary-goal benefit.
- This is where いのち stops being a chapter title and becomes visible on the mountain: mixed broadleaf regrowth supporting deer, birds, insects, and people together is the "one interconnected life community" (— 即一切) the 100-Year Plan describes, not a metaphor for it.

Phase 5 — Steady state: forest and compute grow together, at the forest's pace (Year 5+)

- CHP output and DC compute capacity are sized to sustainable harvest, never the reverse. If the two ever conflict, the ceiling from Phase 2 wins — no renegotiation under demand pressure, exactly the discipline the 1943 collapse shows was missing.
- Revenue funds forest work, workforce, and village priorities the collective sets — it is the fuel for continuing the work, not the reason the work exists.
- Success looks like: standing timber with an economic reason to exist again, a working forest that supports the people tending it, and a supply relationship whose terms nobody had to break to get there.
- Closing frame, in the 100-Year Plan's own words: forests are "the wellspring of life — the source of the homeland of life," and guarding them, cultivating them, is "the fundamental purpose... of a regenerative forestry administration." By Phase 5, that sentence is no longer aspiration — it is what the collective is doing, on schedule, decades after it was first written down.

Sources

Compiled from [\[\[totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes\]\]](#) (Conrad Totman, *Japan's Imperial Forest Goryōrin, 1889–1946* and *The Lumber Industry in Early Modern Japan*), the village's own 日本農村自立再生百年計画 (100-Year Plan) manuscript, いのち/不思議ないのち chapters (see [hundred_year_plan_transcription.md](#)), and Ariel Hernandez's "Reclaiming Care – Homo Curans as Vision for Human Flourishing" (Ch. 13) in *Human Flourishing Across Cultures and Disciplines*, ed. Andrej Zwitter (Bloomsbury, 2026) — paraphrased and attributed; that volume is CC BY-NC-ND with a no-AI/text-mining notice, so quote it directly from the original rather than this document for any formal citation. Plus [\[\[project_reforestation_principle\]\]](#) and [\[\[reference_wildlife_prevention_budget\]\]](#) from project memory. Page-level citations available on request for grant or partner documents.